



PROJECT SANCTUM

A UI / UX DESIGN DOCUMENT

The design system behind a network hidden in plain sight — architecture, ritual, tokens, type, motion, interaction, resilience, and the three arcs that make visitors stay.

AARAV CHOUDHARY · ANUJ PHULERA · JEEHAN KWATRA
COLONELS CENTRAL ACADEMY

THE TWO-LAYER HOUSE

LAYER I - THE COVER

SIGNAL & STATIC — an abandoned shortwave listener’s blog, est. 2008, last transmission March 2013. Serif, justified columns, a dead guestbook, a hit counter at 001337, webrings. It is its own complete website — believable enough to be judged standing alone.

LAYER II - THE SANCTUM

The hidden network: a boot Seal, a scroll-driven Gate transmission, a draggable rite-orbit, six chambers, a Ceremony, a Departure, and a Field Log dossier — all behind the door, all client-side, all remembered between visits.

THE JOURNEY, TOPOLOGICALLY



WHY TWO LAYERS

Discovery is the product. The cover is **airtight** — no custom cursor, no chrome, no glow leaks: the native arrow pointer is itself part of the disguise. Only finding the door proves the world existed at all, which retroactively re-reads every blog post as a clue. One key, **~**, panics back to the surface instantly from anywhere — cover and Sanctum are a single toggleable reality.

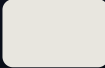
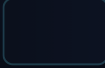
THE UNLOCK RITUAL

#	STEP	DESIGN INTENT
01	READ THE BLOG	Posts are real field notes (UVB-76, the Wow! signal). One — <i>the hum at 0528</i> — teaches the four-digit frequency without ever breaking character.
02	OPEN PHOTOS	Six frames: five plausible, one impossible — a glowing ring in a dead observatory, captioned IMG_0528 — DO NOT .
03	CLICK THE RING ×3	Each click: static flicker, a notch of brightness, a detuning whisper-blip. Escalation earns commitment — three is a ritual, not an accident.
04	THE DOOR ASKS	The page tears open into a code field. Enter 0528 — the blog itself taught it. A static wipe cuts to the Seal bootloader.
05	GIVE YOUR NAME	First entry asks once: <i>"the network must know what to call you."</i> Persisted forever — every later visit opens with WELCOME BACK, {name} .

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

The password is taught, never told. Every element of the ritual is diegetic — the code lives in a story, the door lives in a photograph, the instruction lives in a caption that says the opposite. Security through lore.

DESIGN TOKENS

 INK #07090F · void ground	 KYBER #67E8F9 · the signal · rite I
 KYBER-DIM #2E8FA3 · secondary labels	 EMBER #E8B44C · ritual + rite III
 VIOLET #B79CFF · rite II · identity tinge	 BONE #E8E6DF · foreground copy
 GHOST #9AA3B2 · subdued chrome	 PANEL #0B101C→#0D1322 · card ground

RULE	TOKEN LAW
COLOR = DOMAINS	kyber owns Signal, violet owns Focus, ember owns Choice & the ritual. A glance tells you which system speaks.
ONE GLOW BUDGET	glows stay under 34px blur and 30% alpha; darkness is the default state, light is earned.
BORDERS AT 10-16%	structure lines hold at low alpha — the interface feels etched, not boxed.

TYPOGRAPHY

DISPLAY - CINZEL

THE TRIALS OF AWAKENING

Imperial serified caps for ranks, rites and the wordmark — clamp(30px–76px), weight 700–900, tracking .08–.14em, steel-gradient fill.

BODY - SPACE GROTESK

Hear what hides beneath the static. Hold the beacon while the void pulls.

Interface copy at 12–15px, light weight, 1.6–1.75 leading — quiet, technical, readable against ink.

SYSTEM - IBM PLEX MONO

◆ TRANSMISSION 03/03 - IDENTITY DISCLOSED

Kickers, HUD, codes and quest rows at 8.5–12px with .2–.42em tracking — the network’s own voice.

ROLE	SIZE	TRACKING
Display / ranks	clamp 30–76px	.08–.2em
Body / hints	12.5–15px	.01–.14em
Mono / kickers	8.5–12px	.2–.5em

MOTION LANGUAGE

SIGNATURE	DURATION / EASE	BEHAVIOUR
SCRAMBLE DECODE	16-70ms/char · linear	Every message arrives as glyph-noise sweeping left→right into truth — decryption as typography.
STATIC WIPE	.36s · steps(5)	Layer changes (blog ⇌ Sanctum) cut through full-screen static — a channel change, not a page load.
RITE ORBIT	.55s · power3 / back.out	Three rites ride a 3D carousel with real throw physics — drags carry inertia, wheels notch by 120° with a mechanical tick.
SIGIL BLOOM	.7s · cubic-bezier(.2,.8,.2,1)	Identity arcs draw on one-by-one, staggered 110ms — a louder record draws a denser mark.
RANK SLAM	.62s · power4.in	The ceremony's rank lands from 3× scale with an impact, a flash and a seven-frame shake.
THE FOLD	scroll-driven · smoothstep	Departure transmissions dissolve reversed — blur, tracking-out, and lift compose the forgetting.

TWO LAWS

I. Wall-clock gates, rAF paints. Anything that scores or gates (seal lift, quest fires, wave timers) reads real elapsed time; animation only mirrors it — throttled tabs never corrupt a verdict.

II. State-driven entrances. Motion begins after the interface commits, so a reopened chamber replays its theater cleanly every time.

INTERACTION MODEL

KEYBOARD MAP

KEY	ACTION
~	panic — blog ⇌ Sanctum, instantly, anywhere
Esc / burger	open the Field Log dossier
1-5	Field Log tab jump
↑ ↑ ↓ ↓	lift the Seal at once (knowing hands only)
Ctrl+Alt+D	forget everything — full registry wipe
wheel / drag	spin the rite-orbit, steer every chamber

THE CURSOR SPEAKS

One ring cursor, a labeled aura — BEGIN · REPLAY · SEALED · **APPROACH** · DRAG · TUNE · HOLD · CHOOSE · DEPART · RETURN — so intent is announced before the click.

THE NAME REGISTRY

Asked once, kept forever. The Seal greets **WELCOME BACK, {name}**; after the Ceremony it greets by **callsign**. Identity persists across sessions, upgrades, and the Departure itself.

PERSISTENCE

Every rite score, quest, mote, path walked, streak best, rank and sigil lives in a versioned local save — migrate-safe, offline-first, zero accounts, zero servers. Your legend survives the browser closing.

THE FIELD LOG

One Esc from anywhere: a five-tab dossier — IDENTITY (sigil · rank · totals) · TASK LOG (rites & echoes) · QUESTS (nineteen, with live progress) · ARCHIVE (restored fragments & walked paths) · SIGNAL (attunement & mute). It reads the same truthful save; it never invents state.

ACCESSIBILITY & RESILIENCE

SURFACE	PROVISION
REDUCED MOTION	<code>prefers-reduced-motion</code> collapses ambient theater (orbits idle, pulses still, wipes flatten) while every control, scroll-journey and verdict stays fully operable.
AUDIO BY CONSENT	The sound engine arms on the visitor's first gesture — never autoplaying, never surprising — and a persistent mute lives in the Field Log's SIGNAL tab.
CONTRAST	Bone-on-ink body text holds $\approx 13:1$; kyber-on-ink $\approx 11:1$; ghost text is decorative or redundant only — meaning never rests on the dimmest ink.
TOUCH PARITY	Every drag has a wheel/tap twin: the orbit notches on scroll, chambers accept taps, no mechanic requires a right hand.
GPU GRACE	If WebGL is absent the portal degrades itself to a pure-CSS rite ("TURBINE MODE") with the same beats, copy and scoring — the journey never gates on hardware.
FAIL-SOFT SAVE	The registry migrates forward across versions; a corrupt state refuses to hard-lock the door — the cover re-opens and the ritual re-teaches itself.

THE STANCE

Mystery is a mood, not a barrier. Everything secret in SANCTUM is discoverable by design — and everything essential is reachable by anyone.

HEARTS · MINDS · WALLETS

HEARTS

WHY IT MOVES

Melancholy first: a dead blog, a keeper who stopped transmitting in 2013. Then the impossible photograph — and the visitor is no longer browsing, they are trespassing. The network asks their name and never forgets it. The Ceremony speaks their callsign aloud; the Departure lets them grieve leaving. Emotion is engineered as a sequence: curiosity → trespass → belonging → legacy.

MINDS

WHY IT TEACHES

Signal trains real ears — tuning against drift, dual-voice separation, a 26-detent cipher wheel. Focus is attention made physical, including a decoy that punishes the fooled. Choice models consequence without preaching: every verdict immediately becomes a playable proof. Nineteen quests reward the precise behaviors of a curious mind — read everything, walk both sides of tomorrow, come back faster.

WALLETS

WHY IT LASTS

Zero install, zero accounts, zero servers — a static build that runs anywhere a browser does and persists forever on-device. Replayability is systemic: an endless master band, six walkable paths, rank promotions, a sigil that is provably yours. And the two-layer *cover + rite* architecture is a format, not a one-off — any world can hide behind anything.

THE SYNTHESIS

Feel like you found something forbidden · learn like the machine trusts you · keep what you earned forever — **THAT IS THE WHOLE LEDGER.**

WE HIDE IN PLAIN SIGHT

TEAM CCA — PROJECT SANCTUM

AARAV CHOUDHARY · ANUJ PHULERA · JEEHAN KWATRA
COLONELS CENTRAL ACADEMY · TS '26 CREATIVE